

Orange / Ortanique Grow Guide

Practical guide for growing orange and ortanique citrus trees in Jamaica

WhatsApp/Call: 1-876-372-7415

Quick expectations - specific numbers to plan with

What to expect	Planning number
Tree type	Citrus tree - orange / ortanique. Care is similar for many sweet orange and tangor-type citrus trees.
Best location	Full sun, open airflow, and well-drained soil. Avoid low wet areas.
Sunlight	6-8+ hours of direct sun daily is the target.
First fruiting	About 2-4 years for grafted trees under good care. Young trees may flower earlier but hold little fruit.
Managed height	Keep around 8-12 feet tall for easier harvesting and care.
Unpruned height	Many orange or ortanique trees can reach 15-25+ feet depending on variety, rootstock, and conditions.
Canopy spread	Often 10-20+ feet wide if allowed to develop.
Spacing	Plant about 12-20 feet apart for home gardens; use wider spacing for full-size trees.
Soil pH	Best around pH 6.0-6.5. Slightly acidic soil is ideal.
Water need	Deep watering during establishment and dry weather. Avoid roots sitting in water.
Main warning	Do not plant too deep, do not bury the graft union, and do not pile mulch against the trunk.

Note: Ortanique is commonly treated as a mandarin-orange type citrus. This guide is written for practical home and small-grower care.

1. Where to plant

- Choose a place with **6-8+ hours of direct sun** per day.
- Use soil that drains well. Citrus roots can suffer if the soil stays waterlogged.
- Avoid planting in low spots where rainwater settles for long periods.
- Give the tree enough space for a canopy about **10-20 feet wide**.
- Avoid planting too close to walls, drains, septic lines, paved areas, or large shade trees.
- Keep the area around young citrus trees free from lawn grass and weeds so roots do not have to compete for water and food.

2. Prepare the planting hole or bed

- Clear grass and weeds from a circle about **2-3 feet wide** around the planting spot.
- Dig a hole wider than the root ball, but not much deeper than the pot or bag.
- Loosen the surrounding soil so new roots can spread outward.
- Use mostly the native soil to refill the hole. If the soil is poor, mix compost into the wider planting area.
- Do not put fresh manure or strong fertilizer directly on the roots.
- If the area gets very wet, plant on a **raised mound** or raised row so extra water can run off.
- Water the hole before planting if the soil is dry.

3. Transplanting steps

- Plant in the **late afternoon**, early evening, or on a cloudy day.
- Remove the bag or pot carefully and keep the root ball together.
- Plant at the **same depth** the tree was growing in the bag or pot.
- If the tree is grafted, keep the **graft union above the soil line**. Do not bury it.
- Press soil gently around the root ball and water deeply immediately after planting.
- Add mulch around the tree, but keep mulch about **6 inches away from the trunk**.
- Stake only if the tree is loose or in a windy spot.

4. Watering schedule for Jamaica

Stage	Watering guide
Day of transplanting	Water deeply immediately after planting.
First 7 days	Water daily unless rain keeps the soil moist.
Weeks 2-4	Water every 1-2 days in hot dry weather. Do not let the root zone dry out completely.
After 1 month	Water 2-3 times weekly in dry weather, or more often if the soil dries quickly.
Established tree	Water deeply when the top few inches of soil become dry. Skip watering after good rain.
Flowering / fruiting	Avoid drought stress. Steady moisture helps fruit hold, fruit size, and tree health.
Best method	Water at the base of the tree so the root zone is soaked well. Avoid only light sprinkling.

5. Soil, drainage, and pH

- Citrus grows best in **fertile, well-drained soil**. Sandy loam, loam, and clay loam can work if drainage is good.
- Best soil pH is about **6.0-6.5**. Slightly acidic soil helps nutrient availability.
- A practical irrigation water pH target is about **6.0-7.0**. Very alkaline water can contribute to nutrient issues over time.
- If the soil is heavy clay, use a raised mound or raised bed. If the soil is very sandy, use compost and mulch to help hold moisture.
- Avoid compacted soil, salty soil, standing water, and planting too deep.

6. Feeding / fertilizer

- Do not over-fertilize immediately after transplanting. Let the tree settle for about **7-14 days**.
- After new growth starts, feed lightly with a **citrus fertilizer** or balanced fruit-tree fertilizer according to the label.
- Citrus commonly needs nitrogen, potassium, magnesium, iron, zinc, manganese, and other micronutrients.
- Young trees can be fed lightly every **6-8 weeks** during active growth.
- Bearing trees can be fed before strong growth flushes and before fruit development, then supported again after harvest.
- Do not push too much nitrogen when the tree is flowering or setting fruit. Too much leafy growth can reduce fruiting.
- If leaves yellow between the veins, check for high pH, poor drainage, or micronutrient deficiency.

7. Roots and mulching

- Citrus feeder roots are often close to the upper soil where oxygen, water, and nutrients are available.
- Do not bury the trunk or root crown. If grafted, do not bury the graft union.
- Keep mulch wide, not high. Mulch should sit around the tree like a **wide blanket**, not like a volcano against the trunk.
- Keep grass and weeds away from the root zone, especially while the tree is young.
- Avoid chopping, digging, burning, or compacting the soil close to the tree.
- Do not let the root zone stay waterlogged.

8. Pruning and clipping

- Citrus does not need heavy pruning to fruit. Heavy pruning can remove fruiting wood and reduce production.
- Prune mainly to remove dead, diseased, weak, crossing, or broken branches.
- Remove branches touching the ground or growing into the center if they block airflow.
- Remove any shoots growing from below the graft union. These are rootstock suckers and can take energy from the fruiting tree.
- Best pruning time is usually after harvest or when the tree is not carrying a heavy flowering or fruiting load.
- Keep the tree around **8-12 feet tall** if you want easier harvesting and spraying.

9. Fruiting expectations

- Grafted orange and ortanique trees often start fruiting in about **2-4 years** under good care.
- Young trees may flower early, but they may drop many flowers or small fruits because the tree is still building strength.
- Light fruiting in the first few years is normal. Stronger harvests usually come when the canopy and root system are well established.
- Do not let a very small young tree carry too many fruits. Building a strong tree first gives better production later.
- Fruit quality improves with full sun, steady water, balanced feeding, and healthy leaves.

10. What promotes flowering and fruiting?

- **Full sun** is one of the biggest helpers for flowering and sweet fruit.
- A mature, healthy tree with strong leaves and roots will hold fruit better.
- Steady deep watering during flowering and fruit swelling helps reduce fruit drop.
- Balanced citrus feeding supports flowers, fruit set, fruit size, and leaf health.
- Good potassium and micronutrients help fruit development.
- Good airflow and light pruning reduce disease pressure and help sunlight reach the canopy.
- Pollinators can help. Avoid spraying insecticide directly on open flowers.
- Prevent waterlogging, trunk damage, heavy weed competition, and severe pest pressure.

11. Pest and disease watch

- Check young leaves regularly for aphids, mites, citrus leafminer, scale insects, and mealybugs.
- Control ants because ants often protect scale insects, aphids, and mealybugs.
- Black coating on leaves is often sooty mold, which grows where sucking insects leave sticky honeydew.

- Water the root zone instead of keeping the trunk constantly wet.
- Keep the area clean and remove dead, diseased, or badly damaged material.
- If a tree declines even though it is watered, check for root rot, waterlogging, trunk injury, or serious disease.

12. Common problems

Problem	Likely cause
Yellow leaves	Nutrient deficiency, high pH, overwatering, poor drainage, or root stress.
Leaves curling	Pests, heat stress, drought, or citrus leafminer.
Flowers but drops fruit	Young tree, drought stress, weak nutrition, poor pollination, or weather stress.
Fruit splitting	Irregular watering or heavy rain after a dry spell.
Tree grows but no fruit	Tree too young, too much shade, too much nitrogen, or poor overall care.
Black coating on leaves	Sooty mold from scale, aphids, whiteflies, or mealybugs.
Dieback	Root rot, disease, drought stress, trunk injury, or poor drainage.
Shoots below graft	Rootstock suckers. Remove them early.

13. Best care routine

First month

- Water regularly and keep the root zone moist, not swampy.
- Keep mulch around the tree but away from the trunk.
- Keep grass and weeds away.
- Avoid heavy fertilizer immediately after planting.
- Protect from animals, wind, and weed-whacker damage.

Months 2-6

- Feed lightly during active growth.
- Water during dry weather.
- Watch new leaves for pests.
- Remove rootstock suckers if the tree is grafted.
- Keep the planting area clean and mulched.

Mature tree

- Feed with citrus fertilizer during active growth.
- Water deeply during dry spells, flowering, and fruit swelling.
- Prune lightly after harvest.

- Keep the canopy sunny and healthy.
- Harvest when fruit is mature for the variety.

Best simple formula

Full sun + good drainage + steady deep watering + citrus feeding + mulch away from trunk + light pruning = healthier orange and ortanique trees.

Sources used for this guide

- UF/IFAS Extension citrus publications - used for general citrus planting, pruning, fertilizing, soil pH, and home citrus care guidance.
- University of California Agriculture and Natural Resources citrus guidance - used for watering, micronutrient symptoms, and nonbearing/light-bearing young tree expectations.
- Caribbean and tropical fruit-growing experience - used to adapt watering and establishment guidance for warm Jamaican conditions.